More Paid Work, the Same Unpaid Load: Gender Gaps in Time Use in India, 2019–2024

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Abstract

Official labour force statistics record a steep rise in Indian women's employment after 2019. Time diaries show what that rise meant for how women spend the day. I compare India's nationally representative Time Use Surveys of 2019 and 2024 (770,848 diaries of persons aged 15 and over). After harmonising the two surveys, I decompose changes across the full 1,440-minute day. Women's mean time in employment rose by 11.1 minutes a day, almost entirely because more women worked on the diary day (20.6% to 23.7%); minutes per worker did not change. About 8 in 10 of these minutes reflect a shift of women out of domestic duties and into self-employment and salaried work as their principal activity. Women's unpaid domestic and care work did not fall: less time cleaning was offset by more childcare, and the gender gap in unpaid work narrowed by only 3.2 minutes, to 289 minutes a day. Men's employment time rose about twice as much as women's, partly through a shift out of own-use production, so the gender gap in production work was unchanged. Reweighting the 2019 population to the 2024 composition enlarges rather than removes the rise in women's paid work. Gains in paid work were largest for women aged 35 to 59 and women with little schooling; women with secondary or higher education recorded more unpaid work and small paid-work gains. The new paid work has so far been added to women's days rather than redistributing their unpaid work.

Keywords: time use; unpaid care work; female labour force participation; gender gaps;

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India; time diaries

1 Introduction

Women's employment in India has been one of the most debated questions in development economics. For more than a decade the debate was about decline: survey after survey found that fewer women were working even as the economy grew, fertility fell and girls' schooling rose (Afridi, Dinkelman, & Mahajan, 2018; Chatterjee, Desai, & Vanneman, 2018; Klasen & Pieters, 2015; Mehrotra & Parida, 2017). That pattern has reversed in the official statistics. In India's Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS), the worker-population ratio of women aged 15 and over on the usual-status measure rose from 23.3 percent in 2018–19 to 40.3 percent in 2023–24 (National Sample Survey Office, 2024; Press Information Bureau, 2024). A rise of this size in five years is unusual, and it raises two questions that labour force surveys cannot answer on their own. How much additional time in paid work does the rise represent? And did women's unpaid domestic and care work, which in India takes a very large share of women's time (Hirway, 2015; Hirway & Jose, 2011), fall as their paid work rose?

Time diaries can answer both questions, because they record every activity over a full day and the minutes must add up to 1,440. India has now fielded two nationally representative Time Use Surveys (TUS), in calendar years 2019 and 2024, with the same 24-hour diary design and the same activity classification. Together they provide 770,848 diaries of persons aged 15 and over. This paper uses the two surveys to measure how the gendered allocation of time changed over the period in which the official employment rate rose.

The paper makes three contributions. First, it measures the employment rise in minutes rather than in status. Women's mean time in employment rose by 11.1 minutes (95% CI [8.5, 13.6]) a day. The increase came almost entirely on the extensive margin: the share of women doing any employment on the diary day rose from 20.6 to 23.7 percent, while minutes per participating woman stayed at about 356. A shift-share decomposition by usual principal activity status shows that about 81 percent of the rise reflects women moving out of domestic duties and into self-employment and regular salaried work, and the rest reflects more time in employment within a status.

Second, the paper accounts for the whole day. Women's unpaid domestic and care work

fell by 2.2 minutes (95% CI [-0.6, 5.1]), a change that cannot be distinguished from zero. Beneath that stability, time spent cleaning and maintaining the dwelling fell by 11.8 minutes and childcare rose by 9.9 minutes. The additional paid minutes therefore came mainly from less self-care and own-use production, not from a net reduction in unpaid work. The gender gap in unpaid work narrowed by 3.2 minutes, from 292 to 289 minutes a day. Men's time in employment rose by more than women's, partly because men shifted time from own-use production into employment, so the gender gap in all production work did not change. Men also gained more free time than women.

Third, the paper asks whether these changes reflect changes in who women are, and for whom the changes occurred. Reweighting the 2019 population to the 2024 distribution of age, education, marital status, household structure, consumption and state (DiNardo, Fortin, & Lemieux, 1996) increases the estimated rise in women's employment time to 14.1 minutes, so compositional change does not explain it. The rise was largest among women aged 45 to 59 and women with less than primary schooling, who also recorded less unpaid work. Younger women and women with secondary or higher education recorded little additional paid work and more unpaid work, mostly childcare.

Two recent studies compare the 2019 and 2024 surveys. Krishnamurthy (2025) reports national descriptive trends, and Kumar, Bathla, & Singh (2026) study rural working-age adults with a focus on agriculture, finding higher participation of rural women in agricultural work alongside persistently high unpaid domestic time. The present paper differs in covering the whole population aged 15 and over, in documenting what is and is not comparable between the two surveys, in separating extensive and intensive margins and status composition from within-status change, in a composition-adjusted comparison, and in a full 1,440-minute accounting for both sexes.

The findings connect India's employment debate with the international literature on gender convergence in time use. In high-income countries, women's rising employment was followed, slowly and incompletely, by men doing more unpaid work (Altintas & Sullivan, 2016; Bianchi et al., 2000; Gershuny, 2000; Kan, Sullivan, & Gershuny, 2011; Sayer, 2005), a pattern that England (2010) described as uneven and stalled. In India between 2019 and 2024, women's

paid work rose while the division of unpaid work barely moved. The results are descriptive. The two surveys are repeated cross-sections, and the period includes the COVID-19 pandemic, so I do not attribute the changes to any single cause or policy.

2 Background

2.1 Women's employment in India

The decline in women's labour force participation in India between the mid-2000s and 2017–18 has been attributed to rising household incomes, to rising enrolment in education, to a shortage of jobs considered suitable for women, to social norms that restrict women's mobility and work outside the home, and to the measurement of women's work (Afridi, Dinkelman, & Mahajan, 2018; Chatterjee, Desai, & Vanneman, 2018; Jayachandran, 2021; Klasen & Pieters, 2015; Mehrotra & Parida, 2017). Panel evidence shows high rates of entry into and exit from work (Sarkar, Sahoo, & Klasen, 2019), so women's measured employment is sensitive to the reference period and to how intermittent, home-based and family work is recorded.

Measurement is a long-standing concern. Labour force surveys classify a person by status over a reference period, while much of women's work in India is part-time, seasonal, home-based or done in family enterprises (Hirway, 2015; Hirway & Jose, 2011). Deshpande & Kabeer (2024) show that women's work in India is distributed across income generation, expenditure-saving production for the household and unpaid domestic work, and that norms shape the distribution. Time-use data record the same activities in minutes on a given day, so they can show whether a change in status corresponds to a change in time spent working (Vijayamba & Swaminathan, 2024).

From 2018–19 the official rates rose steadily. The PLFS usual-status worker-population ratio for women aged 15 and over rose in every year, from 23.3 percent in 2018–19 to 40.3 percent in 2023–24, and the labour force participation rate rose from 24.5 to 41.7 percent (Press Information Bureau, 2024). The time-use surveys provide an independent measurement of the same period with a different instrument.

2.2 Time use and gender convergence

Studies of time use in high-income countries since the 1960s find that women's paid work rose and their unpaid work fell, while men's unpaid work rose slowly. The gap in unpaid work narrowed mainly because women did less housework rather than because men did more (Altintas & Sullivan, 2016; Bianchi et al., 2000; Sayer, 2005). Gender gaps in time use are also widest in the life-course stages in which young children are present (Anxo et al., 2011). Goldin (2006) and England (2010) describe the change in women's paid work as larger and faster than the change in the domestic division of labour. Evidence from India over the pandemic points the same way: using a household panel, Deshpande (2022) found that men's time in domestic work rose during the 2020 lockdown but moved back towards earlier levels as restrictions eased.

These studies suggest three questions for India. Did the employment rise show up in the time diaries, and on which margin? Did women's unpaid work fall to make room? And did men's unpaid work rise? Because the two Indian surveys use the same diary instrument, they can answer these questions over a period of rapid change in the official employment statistics.

3 Data and comparability

3.1 The two surveys

The Time Use Survey 2019 was conducted by the National Statistical Office (NSO) from January to December 2019 in four quarterly sub-rounds (National Statistical Office, 2020b, 2020a). The Time Use Survey 2024 was conducted from January to December 2024 with the same design (National Statistics Office, 2025b, 2025a). In both surveys every household member aged 6 and over reported the activities of the previous day, from 4:00 a.m. on the day before the interview to 4:00 a.m. on the day of the interview, in 48 half-hour slots. Activities of 10 minutes or more in a slot were recorded with three-digit codes of the International Classification of Activities for Time-Use Statistics 2016 (ICATUS 2016), and one activity in each slot was marked as the major activity. The 2019 survey enumerated 4,47,250 persons aged 6 and over in 1,38,799 households, and the 2024 survey 4,54,192 persons in 1,39,487

households (National Statistical Office, 2020b; National Statistics Office, 2025b). Both surveys use stratified multi-stage samples, with villages and urban blocks as first-stage units and households as second-stage units.

I use the unit-level data released by the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation. For 2019 the files contain 9,436,777 activity records for 445,299 persons with diaries; for 2024 they contain 10,211,478 activity records for 450,457 persons. Following the official estimates that consider only the major activity in a slot, each slot is assigned to its major activity, so every diary sums to 1,440 minutes (all diaries in 2019 and all but 5 in 2024). I exclude persons recorded as third gender (129 in 2019 and 49 in 2024), because the numbers are too small for separate analysis, and restrict the sample to persons aged 15 and over with a recorded day of the week. The analysis sample contains 384,736 diaries of women and 386,112 diaries of men.

3.2 What is comparable

Table 1 summarises the comparison. The activity classification is the same: both surveys use ICATUS 2016 three-digit codes, and the set of codes appearing in the two microdata files is identical. The reference day, slot length, minimum duration, age coverage and diary respondents are the same, and both years were fielded across a full calendar year, so seasonal patterns are balanced. Each person's usual principal activity status, on which the status decomposition in Section 5.3 rests, is recorded with the same codes in both rosters.

3.3 What is not, or not fully, comparable

Four differences limit comparability. First, the 2024 survey was conducted by computer-assisted personal interview (CAPI) (National Statistics Office, 2025b), whereas the 2019 report describes personal interviews without specifying computer assistance (National Statistical Office, 2020b). A change in mode can change how activities are prompted and recorded. Second, the 2024 documentation explicitly caps recorded activities at three per slot. Because I use only the major activity in each slot, the number of simultaneous activities recorded does not affect the estimates, but the choice of the major activity could. Third, the 2024

Table 1: Comparability of the 2019 and 2024 Time Use Surveys

Feature	TUS 2019	TUS 2024	Harmonisation
Fieldwork	Jan–Dec 2019, four sub-rounds	Jan–Dec 2024, four sub-rounds	None needed
Sample design	Stratified two-stage	Stratified two-stage	Year-specific weights; clusters by year and first-stage unit
Persons aged 6+ enumerated	4,47,250	4,54,192	–
Diary reference period	4:00 a.m. to 4:00 a.m.	4:00 a.m. to 4:00 a.m.	None needed
Slot structure	48 slots of 30 minutes	48 slots of 30 minutes	None needed
Activities recorded per slot	Activities of 10+ minutes; one marked major	Up to 3 activities of 10+ minutes; one marked major	Major activity only (sums to 1,440)
Activity classification	ICATUS 2016, 3-digit	ICATUS 2016, 3-digit (same code set)	None needed
Mode of interview	Personal interview	CAPI	Not possible; see text
Proxy-reported diaries, ages 15+	35.5%	33.5%	Robustness: self-reports only
Household roster	All members, incl. under 6	Members aged 6+ only	Under-6 = household size minus diarists, both years
State boundaries	J&K incl. Ladakh; DNH and DD separate	Ladakh separate; DNH and DD merged	Ladakh to J&K; DNH and DD merged
Usual activity status	Principal status, NSS codes	Principal status, NSS codes	Same groups

Note:
Design features from NSO (2020) and NSO (2025). Proxy-reported: weighted share of diaries of persons aged 15+ for which the informant was not the respondent, from the microdata. CAPI: computer-assisted personal interview. J&K: Jammu and Kashmir; DNH and DD: Dadra and Nagar Haveli, and Daman and Diu.

microdata contain no household members under age 6, so the number of young children must be inferred as household size minus the number of diarists. I apply the same residual method to 2019. In the 2019 data, where children under 6 are listed, the residual and the direct count agree on whether a household has a child under 6 for 99.4 percent of diaries. Fourth, the share of diaries reported for a "normal" day is slightly lower in 2024 (Table 2).

These differences matter most for changes that are common to men and women. Both sexes record about 20 fewer minutes of self-care (sleep, eating and personal hygiene) in 2024 and more free time. A real change cannot be ruled out, but a common shift of this kind is also what a change in recording practice would produce. I therefore give most weight to estimates that are less exposed to common recording changes: changes in the gap between women and men, which difference out shifts common to both sexes, and changes in paid and unpaid work, which are the focus of both surveys' published estimates. I also show that the main estimates hold among self-reported diaries, diaries for normal days, and weekday diaries.

As an external check, participation rates estimated from the microdata closely reproduce the official figures. Among persons aged 15 to 59, the official estimates put the share of women participating in employment and related activities at 21.8 percent in 2019 and 25.0 percent in 2024, and the share of men at 70.9 and 75.0 percent (National Statistics Office, 2025b). The corresponding estimates in my data, based on the major activity, are 21.7 and 24.9 percent for women and 70.7 and 74.9 percent for men.

3.4 Activity groups

I group the three-digit codes into the nine ICATUS divisions: (1) employment and related activities, including travel to work; (2) production of goods for own final use, such as farming, animal care and collecting fuel and water for the household; (3) unpaid domestic services for household members; (4) unpaid caregiving for household members; (5) unpaid volunteer, trainee and other unpaid work; (6) learning; (7) socialising, communication, community participation and religious practice; (8) culture, leisure, mass media and sports; and (9) self-care and maintenance. I refer to division 1 as employment or paid work, to divisions 1 and 2 together as production work (both fall within the production boundary of the System of National Accounts), to divisions 3 and 4 as unpaid work, to divisions 7 and 8 as free time, and to divisions 1 to 5 as total work.

4 Methods

All estimates use the survey weights, rescaled within each year so that the two years contribute in proportion to their sample sizes. Standard errors are clustered by first-stage unit within year, and I report 95 percent confidence intervals.

Changes and changes in gaps. For each activity group y, the change in mean minutes for women is the coefficient on a 2024 indicator in a weighted regression of y on that indicator in the women's sample, and likewise for men. The change in the gender gap is the coefficient δ in

$$y_i = \alpha + \beta\,\mathrm{Female}_i + \gamma\,\mathrm{Y2024}_i + \delta\,(\mathrm{Female}_i \times \mathrm{Y2024}_i) + \varepsilon_i.$$

Because the 1,440 minutes of each diary are fully allocated, the changes across the nine divisions sum to zero for each sex.

Extensive and intensive margins. Mean minutes in an activity equal the share of persons doing it on the diary day, p, times the mean minutes among those who do it, m. I split the change into an extensive part, $\Delta p \cdot \bar{m}$, and an intensive part, $\Delta m \cdot \bar{p}$, where bars denote averages of the two years; the two parts sum to the total change.

Status shift-share. Women's mean minutes equal $\sum_k s_k \mu_k$, where s_k is the share of women in usual principal activity status k (self-employed, unpaid family helper, regular wage or salaried, casual labour, domestic duties, student, and other) and μ_k is mean minutes in that status. The change splits into a between-status part, $\sum_k \Delta s_k \bar{\mu}_k$, which captures movement of women across statuses, and a within-status part, $\sum_k \bar{s}_k \Delta \mu_k$, which captures changes in time use among women with the same status. Status is reported for the past year and the diary for one day, so the decomposition links the status-based and time-based measures of work.

Composition adjustment. To ask whether changes in the population's composition explain the changes in time use, I reweight the 2019 sample to the 2024 distribution of observed characteristics (DiNardo, Fortin, & Lemieux, 1996; Fortin, Lemieux, & Firpo, 2011). A weighted logit of the 2024 indicator on age group by sector, education by sector, marital status, household size, presence of a child under 6, state, within-year consumption quintile, sub-round and day of the week gives the predicted probability $\hat{p}(X)$. Each 2019 observation's weight is multiplied by $\hat{p}(X)/(1-\hat{p}(X))$ and scaled by the ratio of the year shares. The difference between the 2024 mean and the reweighted 2019 mean is the change holding these characteristics at their 2024 distribution. Status is not included, because it is an outcome of the same process. The effective sample size of the reweighted 2019 sample is 95 percent of that with the original weights for women and 97 percent for men, so the reweighting does not rest on a few observations.

5 Results

5.1 Sample

Table 2 describes the analysis sample. The two populations are similar. Between 2019 and 2024 the share of women with at least a graduate degree rose from 9.8 to 11.7 percent, and the share with less than primary schooling fell from 40.1 to 33.5 percent. The share of women whose usual principal status was a form of employment rose from 21.9 to 25.3 percent, an increase of 3.3 percentage points (95% CI [2.6, 4.0]). The TUS records only usual principal status, whereas the PLFS figures cited above combine principal and subsidiary status and refer to agricultural years (July to June). The levels and changes are therefore not directly comparable, but the TUS principal-status measure rose much less than the PLFS usual-status measure over a similar period.

Table 2: Analysis sample, persons aged 15 and over

Characteristic	Women 2019	Women 2024	Men 2019	Men 2024
Diaries (N)	189,794	194,942	192,207	193,905
Mean age (years)	38.5	39.0	38.3	38.9
Urban (%)	30.5	30.9	31.5	32.7
Currently married (%)	71.5	70.9	68.1	68.1
Graduate or above (%)	9.8	11.7	13.5	16.1
Below primary (%)	40.1	33.5	24.2	19.5
Employed, usual principal status (%)	21.9	25.3	76.2	77.9
Child under 6 in household (%)	35.3	37.4	32.1	33.8
Normal day (%)	93.2	91.8	91.0	89.1
Self-reported diary (%)	70.4	73.2	58.6	59.8
Sunday diary (%)	13.7	13.7	13.6	13.8

Note:
Weighted means and shares, except N. Child under 6: household size minus the number of diarists is positive (both years). Self-reported diary: the informant was the respondent.

5.2 Paid work rose on the extensive margin

Table 3 reports mean minutes per day in each activity group for women and men in both years, the change, and the change in the gender gap. Women's time in employment rose from 73.5 to 84.5 minutes a day, an increase of 11.1 minutes (95% CI [8.5, 13.6]). Men's rose from 324.8 to 347.4 minutes, an increase of 22.6 minutes (95% CI [18.8, 26.4]).

Table 4 splits the changes into extensive and intensive parts. For women, virtually all of the

Table 3: Mean minutes per day by sex, 2019 and 2024, persons aged 15 and over

	Women			Men			Gap (women minus men)		
Activity (ICATUS division)	2019	2024	Change (SE)	2019	2024	Change (SE)	2019	2024	Change (SE)
Employment (1)	73.5	84.5	11.1 (1.3)	324.8	347.4	22.6 (1.9)	-251.3	-262.9	-11.6 (2.0)
Own-use production (2)	27.3	24.8	-2.5 (0.8)	34.2	20.7	-13.5 (1.0)	-6.9	4.1	10.9 (0.8)
Production work (1+2)	100.8	109.4	8.6 (1.4)	359.0	368.1	9.2 (1.6)	-258.2	-258.8	-0.6 (1.9)
Unpaid domestic services (3)	293.1	280.4	-12.7 (1.3)	30.5	28.0	-2.4 (0.5)	262.6	252.3	-10.3 (1.3)
Food and meals	190.5	192.8	2.3 (1.0)	6.5	6.7	0.2 (0.2)	184.0	186.1	2.1 (1.1)
Cleaning and upkeep	53.6	41.9	-11.8 (0.4)	4.7	3.5	-1.2 (0.1)	49.0	38.4	-10.6 (0.4)
Unpaid caregiving (4)	41.1	51.5	10.4 (0.6)	11.8	15.2	3.4 (0.3)	29.3	36.3	7.0 (0.5)
Childcare	39.6	49.5	9.9 (0.6)	10.9	14.0	3.1 (0.2)	28.7	35.6	6.8 (0.5)
Unpaid work (3+4)	334.2	331.9	-2.2 (1.5)	42.3	43.2	1.0 (0.6)	291.9	288.7	-3.2 (1.4)
Total work (1–5)	437.2	442.7	5.5 (1.5)	404.5	412.8	8.3 (1.6)	32.7	29.9	-2.8 (1.8)
Learning (6)	40.3	40.7	0.4 (0.7)	53.0	47.9	-5.1 (0.9)	-12.8	-7.2	5.5 (0.9)
Free time (7+8)	232.8	245.8	13.0 (1.4)	240.2	260.9	20.7 (1.4)	-7.5	-15.1	-7.6 (1.2)
Self-care and maintenance (9)	729.7	710.8	-18.9 (1.2)	742.2	718.4	-23.8 (1.1)	-12.5	-7.6	4.9 (0.9)
Sleep	550.0	543.6	-6.4 (1.0)	539.1	532.5	-6.6 (0.9)	10.9	11.1	0.2 (0.7)

Note:
Weighted means over all persons, including those who did not do the activity. Major activity in each 30-minute slot. Standard errors clustered by first-stage unit within year. N = 384,736 women and 386,112 men.

rise in employment time (11.1 of 11.1 minutes) came from the extensive margin. The share of women who did any paid work on the diary day rose by 3.1 percentage points (95% CI [2.4, 3.8]), from 20.6 to 23.7 percent, while women who worked spent 356 minutes on it in 2019 and 356 in 2024. The new paid work therefore resembles women's existing paid work in duration. It is not dominated by short spells, as might be expected if it mainly reflected a reclassification of marginal activities. For men, the extensive margin also accounts for most of the rise, with participation rising by 4.2 percentage points.

Own-use production moved in the other direction, most clearly for men. Men's minutes in own-use production fell by 13.5 minutes (95% CI [11.4, 15.5]), mostly because men who did any own-use production spent less time on it (213 minutes in 2019 and 144 in 2024). The boundary between division 1 (for example, work on a family farm whose output is mainly sold) and division 2 (work whose output is mainly for the household's own use) depends on the intended use of the output, so a shift across it could reflect a change in market orientation or in coding. When the two divisions are combined, production work rose by 8.6 minutes (95% CI [5.8, 11.3]) for women and 9.2 minutes (95% CI [6.0, 12.4]) for men, and the gender gap in production work did not change (change of -0.6 minutes, 95% CI [-4.3, 3.1]). Measured by employment alone, the gap widened by 11.6 minutes (95% CI [7.7, 15.4]).

Table 4: Participation and minutes per participant: decomposition of the change

	Participation (%)		Minutes per participant		Change in mean minutes		
Activity	2019	2024	2019	2024	Total	Extensive	Intensive
Women							
Employment (1)	20.6	23.7	356	356	11.1	11.1	0.0
Own-use production (2)	21.6	22.5	126	110	-2.5	1.1	-3.6
Production work (1+2)	37.9	41.6	266	263	8.6	9.7	-1.1
Unpaid domestic services (3)	89.9	90.5	326	310	-12.7	2.1	-14.8
Unpaid caregiving (4)	29.2	36.1	141	143	10.4	9.8	0.6
Unpaid work (3+4)	91.2	92.1	366	360	-2.2	3.1	-5.4
Men							
Employment (1)	66.9	71.0	486	489	22.6	20.4	2.3
Own-use production (2)	16.1	14.4	213	144	-13.5	-3.0	-10.4
Production work (1+2)	74.7	76.4	480	482	9.2	7.9	1.3
Unpaid domestic services (3)	27.9	28.5	109	98	-2.4	0.6	-3.1
Unpaid caregiving (4)	13.7	18.4	86	83	3.4	4.0	-0.6
Unpaid work (3+4)	37.0	41.4	114	104	1.0	4.8	-3.8

Note:
Participation: share of persons with any minutes in the activity on the diary day. Extensive = change in participation times the two-year mean of minutes per participant; intensive = change in minutes per participant times the two-year mean participation. The two parts sum to the total.

5.3 Who the new working women are

Table 5 decomposes the change in women's employment and unpaid work by usual principal activity status. The share of women whose principal status was domestic duties fell from 61.4 to 58.4 percent, while the share of self-employed women (own-account workers and employers) rose from 4.8 to 6.9 percent and the share in regular wage or salaried work from 5.1 to 6.0 percent; the shares of unpaid family helpers and casual labourers changed little.

The between-status component accounts for 9.0 of the 11.1-minute rise in women's employment time, and the within-status component for 2.1 minutes. The largest single contribution, 5.2 minutes, comes from the growth of self-employment, followed by regular salaried work (3.4 minutes). Within statuses, unpaid family helpers spent 49.5 minutes (95% CI [37.5, 61.4]) more in employment in 2024 than in 2019, and casual labourers 22.9 minutes (95% CI [14.1, 31.7]) more (Table 10 in the appendix). Self-employed and salaried women spent about as much time in employment in 2024 as in 2019, so the women who joined these statuses brought with them the employment time typical of each status. In the TUS, women's status and their time use moved together.

Table 5: Women's time use by usual principal activity status: shift-share decomposition

	Share (%)		Employment minutes				Unpaid work minutes			
Usual principal status	2019	2024	2019	2024	Between	Within	2019	2024	Between	Within
Self-employed	4.8	6.9	251	247	5.2	-0.3	270	289	5.9	1.1
Unpaid family helper	5.3	5.6	188	237	0.8	2.7	305	297	1.1	-0.5
Regular wage/salaried	5.1	6.0	387	390	3.4	0.2	212	212	1.9	0.0
Casual labour	6.8	6.7	330	353	-0.1	1.5	251	246	-0.1	-0.4
Domestic duties	61.4	58.4	13	10	-0.3	-1.5	416	418	-12.5	1.5
Student	10.0	9.5	9	6	0.0	-0.3	101	90	-0.5	-1.1
Other not working	6.7	6.9	11	6	0.0	-0.3	182	196	0.4	0.9
Total	100.0	100.0	73.5	84.5	9.0	2.1	334.2	331.9	-3.8	1.6

Note:
Women aged 15 and over. Self-employed: own-account workers and employers. Between = change in status share times the two-year mean minutes in that status; within = change in mean minutes in that status times the two-year mean share. The components sum to the total change. Other not working: the unemployed, rentiers, pensioners, persons unable to work and others.

The decomposition of unpaid work shows why women's unpaid work did not fall. The shift out of domestic duties reduced women's mean unpaid work by 12.5 minutes, because women whose principal status is domestic duties spend more than 410 minutes a day on unpaid work. But self-employed women, the group that grew most, also do a great deal of unpaid work: 270 minutes in 2019 and 289 minutes in 2024, an increase of 18.3 minutes (95% CI [11.8, 24.9]). Their growing share added 5.9 minutes to women's mean unpaid work. In total, movement across statuses reduced women's unpaid work by only 3.8 minutes, and changes within statuses added 1.6 minutes.

The trade-off between paid and unpaid work is stable. Among women, each additional minute of employment is associated with 0.33 fewer minutes of unpaid work, conditional on age, education, marital status, sector, household composition, state, day of the week and sub-round, and the association is almost identical in the two years (difference -0.007, standard error 0.004). At that rate, the observed rise of 11.1 minutes of employment would be associated with about 3.7 fewer minutes of unpaid work, close to the observed decline of 2.2 minutes.

5.4 The full day: where the minutes came from

Figure 1 shows the change in each of the nine divisions for women and men. Because the day is fixed, the changes for each sex sum to zero. Women's additional 11.1 minutes of employment and 10.4 minutes of caregiving were matched by 12.7 fewer minutes of domestic services, 2.5 fewer minutes of own-use production and 18.9 fewer minutes of self-care, while their free time rose by 13.0 minutes. Men added 22.6 minutes of employment and 20.7 minutes of free time, mainly leisure and mass media, and recorded 13.5 fewer minutes of own-use production, 5.1 fewer of learning and 23.8 fewer of self-care.

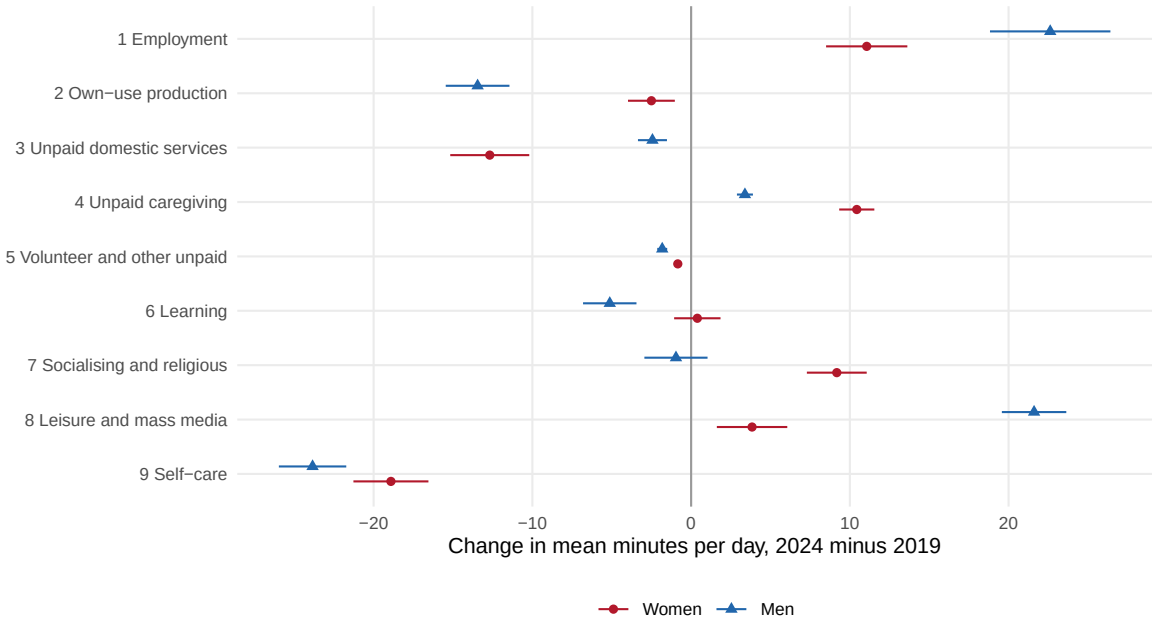


Figure 1: Change in minutes per day between 2019 and 2024 by ICATUS division, persons aged 15 and over. Points are changes in weighted means; bars are 95% confidence intervals clustered by first-stage unit.

The decline in women's domestic services is concentrated in one activity. Time spent cleaning and maintaining the dwelling and surroundings fell from 53.6 to 41.9 minutes, while time spent preparing food and meals was essentially unchanged at about 193 minutes (Table 3). The rise in caregiving is almost all childcare, and it came from more women doing any childcare on the diary day: the share rose from 28.2 to 34.9 percent, with little change in minutes per participant. Men's childcare rose by 3.1 minutes (95% CI [2.6, 3.6]), from a

much lower base, so the gender gap in caregiving widened by 7.0 minutes.

The gender gap in unpaid work narrowed by 3.2 minutes (95% CI [0.5, 5.9]), from 291.9 to 288.7 minutes a day. In 2024 women still did 7.7 times as much unpaid work as men. Women's total work, paid and unpaid, exceeded men's by 30 minutes a day in 2024, compared with 33 minutes in 2019. Men's free time rose more than women's, so the gap in free time in men's favour widened by 7.6 minutes (95% CI [5.2, 10.0]), to 15 minutes a day.

5.5 For whom did time use change?

Table 6 reports changes in women's employment, unpaid work and childcare, men's unpaid work, and the gender gap in unpaid work across population groups. The rise in women's employment time was broad, but its size varied. It was larger among women aged 45 to 59 (21.4 minutes) than among women aged 15 to 29 (3.5 minutes), and larger among women with less than primary schooling (20.6 minutes) than among women with secondary schooling (5.5 minutes) or a degree (6.4 minutes). It was also larger in the richest consumption quintile (17.9 minutes) than in the poorest (4.1 minutes). Figure 2 shows women's age profiles: in 2024 women's employment time was higher at every age from 20 onwards, and the difference between the profiles is largest between ages 35 and 59.

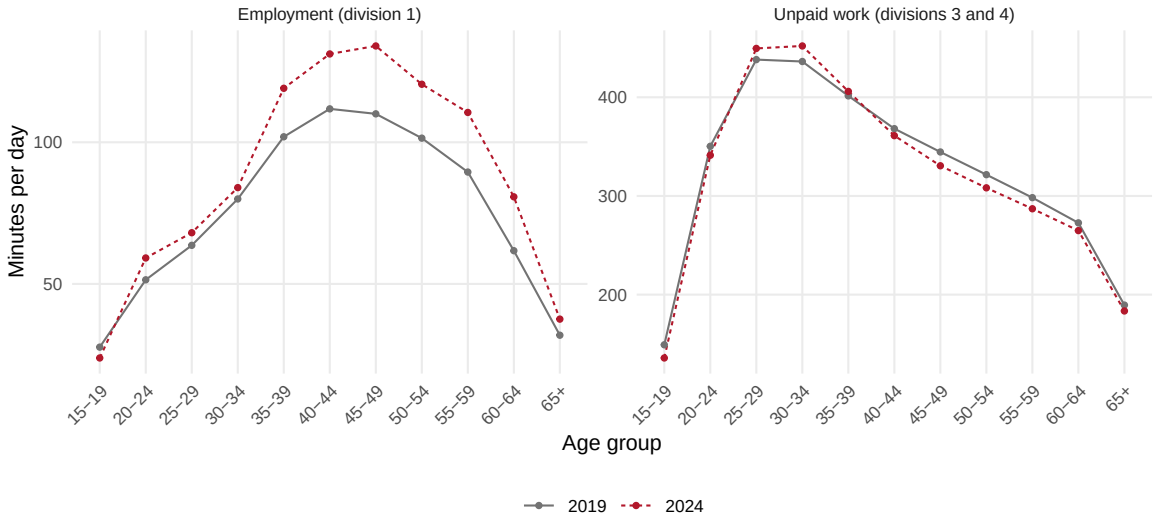


Figure 2: Women's mean minutes per day in employment and in unpaid work by age group, 2019 and 2024.

Table 6: Changes by population group, minutes per day, persons aged 15 and over

	Women: employment		Women: unpaid work		Women: childcare	Men: unpaid	Unpaid gap
Group	2019	Change (SE)	2019	Change (SE)	Change (SE)	Change (SE)	Change (SE)
Sector							
Rural	73.3	11.8 (1.7)	341.5	-4.7 (1.8)	10.4 (0.7)	-1.8 (0.7)	-3.0 (1.7)
Urban	73.8	9.5 (1.8)	317.4	3.6 (2.2)	8.8 (0.9)	6.8 (0.7)	-3.2 (2.2)
Age							
Age 15–29	49.0	3.5 (1.4)	324.1	0.7 (2.3)	12.4 (0.9)	1.4 (0.6)	-0.7 (2.3)
Age 30–44	96.8	12.4 (2.0)	404.6	6.2 (1.9)	15.7 (0.8)	5.7 (0.8)	0.5 (1.9)
Age 45–59	101.3	21.4 (2.3)	323.7	-13.3 (1.9)	3.2 (0.5)	-4.6 (0.8)	-8.7 (1.9)
Age 60+	44.0	10.4 (1.6)	223.1	-8.1 (2.1)	4.0 (0.7)	-4.3 (1.4)	-3.8 (2.2)
Education							
Below primary	87.2	20.6 (2.1)	325.0	-24.2 (2.0)	4.3 (0.7)	-4.1 (0.9)	-20.2 (2.0)
Primary or middle	65.1	11.9 (1.7)	363.8	2.1 (2.1)	10.2 (0.8)	1.0 (0.8)	1.2 (2.2)
Secondary	47.4	5.5 (1.3)	322.5	12.7 (2.3)	12.9 (0.9)	2.8 (0.7)	9.9 (2.2)
Graduate	102.9	6.4 (3.0)	320.3	13.3 (3.4)	11.7 (1.6)	5.7 (0.9)	7.7 (3.3)
Marital status							
Married	70.8	13.1 (1.5)	399.5	-0.9 (1.6)	13.7 (0.7)	2.0 (0.7)	-2.9 (1.5)
Not married	80.3	5.9 (1.7)	170.3	-1.2 (1.5)	1.4 (0.4)	-1.4 (0.6)	0.2 (1.6)
Household							
Child under 6 in household	52.4	9.9 (1.4)	408.9	8.1 (2.0)	23.4 (1.1)	6.6 (0.9)	1.5 (1.9)
No child under 6	84.9	12.9 (1.5)	293.4	-12.5 (1.4)	-1.4 (0.2)	-2.4 (0.5)	-10.0 (1.4)
Consumption quintile (within year)							
Consumption Q1 (poorest)	69.4	4.1 (2.7)	347.6	4.8 (3.0)	18.1 (1.4)	1.8 (1.3)	3.0 (3.0)
Consumption Q5 (richest)	79.9	17.9 (2.1)	313.5	-5.8 (2.3)	1.6 (0.8)	3.0 (0.9)	-8.8 (2.3)

Note:
Unpaid gap: change in the women-minus-men gap in unpaid work (divisions 3 and 4). Groups are defined separately in each year, so changes within a group combine changes in behaviour and in the group's composition. Standard errors clustered by first-stage unit within year.

Changes in unpaid work differed more sharply across groups. Among women with less than primary schooling, unpaid work fell by 24.2 minutes (95% CI [20.3, 28.2]) and the gender gap in unpaid work narrowed by 20.2 minutes. Among women with secondary schooling, unpaid work rose by 12.7 minutes (95% CI [8.3, 17.1]), and among graduates by 13.3 minutes (95% CI [6.7, 19.9]), so the gap widened in both groups. The difference is closely tied to young children. In households with a child under 6, women's childcare rose by 23.4 minutes (95% CI [21.2, 25.6]) and their total unpaid work by 8.1 minutes, while men in these households added 10.2 minutes of childcare. In households without a young child, women's unpaid work fell by 12.5 minutes (95% CI [9.7, 15.2]). Older women and women with little schooling, who less often live with young children, thus combined more paid work with less unpaid work, whereas younger and more educated women, who more often live with young children, recorded more childcare and little additional paid work. Using the direct count of children under 6 for 2019 instead of the residual measure gives the same pattern (21.7 additional minutes of childcare for women in households with a young child).

The groups are defined in each year, and their composition changed as younger, more educated cohorts replaced older ones, so changes within education groups combine changes in behaviour with changes in who is in each group. The reweighting in the next section addresses composition for the population as a whole.

5.6 Composition does not explain the changes

Table 7 compares the raw changes with the changes after the 2019 sample is reweighted to the 2024 distribution of characteristics. For women, the composition-adjusted rise in employment time is 14.1 minutes (95% CI [11.6, 16.6]), larger than the raw rise of 11.1 minutes. Had the 2019 population of women had the 2024 composition (more educated, slightly older and with more young children in the household), their employment time in 2019 would have been lower, at 70.5 minutes rather than 73.5. The adjusted change in women's unpaid work is a decline of 1.5 minutes (95% CI [-1.3, 4.4]), again indistinguishable from zero, and the adjusted rise in their total work is 11.2 minutes (95% CI [8.2, 14.2]). For men, the adjusted and raw changes are close for every activity group. The rise in women's paid work and the stability of their unpaid work are not produced by a changing population.

Table 7: Change in minutes per day, 2019 to 2024, raw and adjusted for composition

	Women		Men	
Activity	Raw	Composition-adjusted	Raw	Composition-adjusted
Employment (1)	11.1 (1.3)	14.1 (1.3)	22.6 (1.9)	22.4 (1.9)
Own-use production (2)	-2.5 (0.8)	-0.5 (0.7)	-13.5 (1.0)	-12.2 (1.0)
Production work (1+2)	8.6 (1.4)	13.5 (1.4)	9.2 (1.6)	10.2 (1.6)
Unpaid domestic services (3)	-12.7 (1.3)	-10.2 (1.3)	-2.4 (0.5)	-3.1 (0.5)
Unpaid caregiving (4)	10.4 (0.6)	8.7 (0.6)	3.4 (0.3)	2.8 (0.3)
Unpaid work (3+4)	-2.2 (1.5)	-1.5 (1.5)	1.0 (0.6)	-0.3 (0.6)
Total work (1–5)	5.5 (1.5)	11.2 (1.5)	8.3 (1.6)	8.0 (1.6)
Free time (7+8)	13.0 (1.4)	9.8 (1.4)	20.7 (1.4)	20.2 (1.4)
Self-care (9)	-18.9 (1.2)	-20.0 (1.2)	-23.8 (1.1)	-23.1 (1.1)

Note:
Composition-adjusted: 2019 reweighted to the 2024 distribution of age group by sector, education by sector, marital status, household size, child under 6, state, within-year consumption quintile, sub-round and day of the week. Standard errors in parentheses, clustered by first-stage unit within year; they do not account for estimation of the weights. Diaries with missing education, consumption or household size are excluded, so raw changes can differ slightly from Table 3.

5.7 Robustness

Table 8 in the appendix repeats the main comparisons in four subsamples: persons aged 15 to 59; diaries for a normal day; self-reported diaries; and diaries for Monday to Friday. In every subsample women's employment time rose by between 11.5 and 13.2 minutes, women's childcare rose by about 10 minutes, and the change in women's unpaid work lay between -3.3 and 0.5 minutes. The gender gap in unpaid work changed by between -3.7 and 0.5 minutes. Restricting to normal days, which excludes holidays, days of illness and other unusual days, gives a larger rise in men's employment time and so a larger widening of the gender gap in employment, but does not change the conclusions about unpaid work. Self-reported diaries, which are not affected by differences in proxy reporting, give the same pattern as the full sample.

6 Discussion

The time diaries confirm that more Indian women did paid work in 2024 than in 2019, and they show that the additional work was substantial in duration: women who worked on the diary day spent close to six hours on it in both years. The size of the change is modest, however, relative to the change in the PLFS usual-status rate. In the diaries, the share of women aged 15 and over doing any paid work on a given day rose by about 3 percentage points, and in the TUS rosters the share of women whose principal status was employment rose by a similar amount. The two kinds of survey measure different things. A usual-status measure counts anyone who worked for a minimum period over a year, including in a subsidiary capacity, whereas a diary measures what happened on one day. Part of the difference may therefore reflect irregular and seasonal work that a usual-status measure counts and a single-day diary often misses. The two sources are best read together. The PLFS shows that more women are attached to work over the year, and the diaries show that by 2024 this had translated into about 11 additional minutes of paid work per woman per day, or about 77 minutes a week.

The central finding is that women's unpaid work did not decline. Three features of the change account for this. First, much of the movement into work was into self-employment,

and self-employed women in India carry unpaid workloads not far below those of women whose principal activity is domestic duties, which is consistent with the home-based and family-enterprise character of much of women's work (Deshpande & Kabeer, 2024). Second, more women recorded childcare. The rise was concentrated among women living with young children, the life-course stage in which gender gaps in time use are widest in other countries as well (Anxo et al., 2011). It could reflect a real increase in time spent with children, or a change in how childcare was reported or recorded between the two rounds, and the data cannot separate the two. Third, men's unpaid work changed little, so there was no reallocation within households of the kind that has gradually narrowed gaps elsewhere (Altintas & Sullivan, 2016; Bianchi et al., 2000). At the 2019–2024 pace, a narrowing of about 0.6 minutes a year, the unpaid-work gap would take centuries to close. This is a mechanical extrapolation, not a forecast, but it conveys how little the division of unpaid work moved.

The heterogeneity suggests two different processes. For older women with little schooling, paid work rose and unpaid work fell. This is consistent with women who are past the stage of caring for young children taking up paid work, and with the rise in rural women's agricultural work documented by Kumar, Bathla, & Singh (2026). For younger and more educated women, paid work rose little and childcare rose. This is the group in which education was expected to raise women's employment, and in which the earlier decline was most puzzling (Chatterjee, Desai, & Vanneman, 2018; Klasen & Pieters, 2015). The diaries suggest that for this group the time demands of caring for young children remained a binding constraint over the period.

Women's free time rose, but less than men's, and both sexes recorded less self-care. Part of this common change may reflect differences in recording between the two surveys, which is why the paper focuses on paid and unpaid work and on changes in gaps. If the decline in self-care is partly a recording change common to women and men, it affects each sex's estimated changes in other activities but largely cancels out of the changes in gender gaps.

The results have several limitations. The surveys are repeated cross-sections, so they describe changes in population averages and cannot follow individual women into and out of work. The period includes the COVID-19 pandemic and its aftermath, as well as changes in rural incomes, prices and public programmes, and the data cannot separate their roles. The diaries

record one day per person; they estimate population averages well but cannot describe the regularity of an individual's work. Using only the major activity in each slot understates activities that are often done alongside others, such as childcare, but the rule is applied in the same way in both years. Finally, the change in interview mode cannot be harmonised, and changes in activities common to both sexes should be read with that in mind.

7 Conclusion

Between 2019 and 2024, India's time-use surveys record a rise in women's paid work that is real, substantial in duration, concentrated on the extensive margin and not explained by changes in the population's composition. They also record that women's unpaid domestic and care work did not fall: less time spent cleaning was offset by more childcare, and men's unpaid work barely changed. So far, the rise in women's employment has been added to women's days rather than redistributing their unpaid work. Efforts to sustain the rise in women's employment, and to extend it to younger and more educated women, may therefore need to address the time women spend on unpaid work, including the care of young children, as well as the supply of jobs. The two surveys provide a baseline against which future rounds can measure both.

Declarations

Data availability. The unit-level data of the Time Use Survey 2019 and the Time Use Survey 2024 are produced by the National Statistics Office, Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation, Government of India, and are available to registered users from the Ministry's microdata portal (catalogs 223 and 236) under its terms of use, which do not permit redistribution. The R code that builds the harmonised person-day files and produces every estimate, table and figure is available to the editor and reviewers on request and will be made public on acceptance.

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Declaration of competing interest. The author declares no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence the work reported in this paper.

Declaration of generative AI and AI-assisted technologies in the manuscript preparation process. Claude (Anthropic) and other AI tools helped with code, reference checks and drafting. The author verified everything and takes full responsibility for the content of the publication.

Ethics. The study is a secondary analysis of anonymised official survey microdata and involved no contact with human subjects.

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Appendix

Table 8: Robustness: change in minutes per day, 2019 to 2024, in subsamples

Activity	Women	Men	Gap (women minus men)
All, aged 15+			
Employment (1)	11.1 (1.3)	22.6 (1.9)	-11.6 (2.0)
Production work (1+2)	8.6 (1.4)	9.2 (1.6)	-0.6 (1.9)
Unpaid work (3+4)	-2.2 (1.5)	1.0 (0.6)	-3.2 (1.4)
Childcare	9.9 (0.6)	3.1 (0.2)	6.8 (0.5)
Total work (1–5)	5.5 (1.5)	8.3 (1.6)	-2.8 (1.8)
Free time (7+8)	13.0 (1.4)	20.7 (1.4)	-7.6 (1.2)
Self-care (9)	-18.9 (1.2)	-23.8 (1.1)	4.9 (0.9)
Aged 15–59			
Employment (1)	11.5 (1.4)	23.1 (2.0)	-11.6 (2.1)
Production work (1+2)	9.0 (1.5)	10.0 (1.7)	-1.0 (2.0)
Unpaid work (3+4)	-0.2 (1.5)	1.8 (0.5)	-2.0 (1.5)
Childcare	11.1 (0.6)	3.4 (0.3)	7.7 (0.5)
Total work (1–5)	7.7 (1.6)	9.8 (1.7)	-2.1 (2.0)
Free time (7+8)	9.5 (1.4)	19.0 (1.4)	-9.5 (1.3)
Self-care (9)	-18.2 (1.2)	-23.2 (1.1)	5.0 (1.0)
Normal days			
Employment (1)	13.2 (1.4)	34.3 (2.0)	-21.1 (2.1)
Production work (1+2)	10.8 (1.5)	19.7 (1.6)	-8.9 (1.9)
Unpaid work (3+4)	0.5 (1.5)	0.0 (0.6)	0.5 (1.4)
Childcare	10.9 (0.6)	3.2 (0.3)	7.7 (0.5)
Total work (1–5)	10.2 (1.6)	17.7 (1.6)	-7.5 (1.8)
Free time (7+8)	10.5 (1.4)	13.6 (1.4)	-3.1 (1.2)
Self-care (9)	-20.0 (1.2)	-25.4 (1.1)	5.5 (1.0)
Self-reported diaries			
Employment (1)	12.6 (1.4)	27.8 (2.3)	-15.3 (2.3)
Production work (1+2)	8.5 (1.5)	10.6 (2.0)	-2.0 (2.1)
Unpaid work (3+4)	-2.6 (1.7)	-0.7 (0.7)	-1.9 (1.6)
Childcare	9.7 (0.6)	1.9 (0.3)	7.8 (0.6)
Total work (1–5)	5.2 (1.7)	8.0 (2.0)	-2.8 (2.1)
Free time (7+8)	11.9 (1.5)	17.5 (1.7)	-5.6 (1.5)
Self-care (9)	-16.7 (1.3)	-22.3 (1.3)	5.6 (1.1)
Monday to Friday			
Employment (1)	12.3 (1.4)	24.9 (2.0)	-12.6 (2.1)
Production work (1+2)	9.9 (1.5)	11.8 (1.7)	-1.9 (2.0)
Unpaid work (3+4)	-3.3 (1.5)	0.4 (0.6)	-3.7 (1.5)
Childcare	9.7 (0.6)	2.9 (0.3)	6.7 (0.5)
Total work (1–5)	5.7 (1.6)	10.3 (1.7)	-4.6 (1.9)
Free time (7+8)	12.2 (1.5)	18.8 (1.5)	-6.6 (1.3)
Self-care (9)	-19.2 (1.2)	-24.1 (1.1)	5.0 (1.0)

Note:
Changes in weighted means, with standard errors in parentheses clustered by first-stage unit within year. Normal day: type of day reported as normal. Self-reported: the informant was the respondent.

Table 9: Mean minutes per day in detailed activity groups, persons aged 15 and over

	Women			Men		
Activity	2019	2024	Change (SE)	2019	2024	Change (SE)
1 Employment	73.5	84.5	11.1 (1.3)	324.8	347.4	22.6 (1.9)
2 Own-use production	27.3	24.8	-2.5 (0.8)	34.2	20.7	-13.5 (1.0)
Fetching water and fuel	7.5	7.4	-0.1 (0.3)	1.8	2.1	0.3 (0.1)
3 Unpaid domestic services	293.1	280.4	-12.7 (1.3)	30.5	28.0	-2.4 (0.5)
Food and meals	190.5	192.8	2.3 (1.0)	6.5	6.7	0.2 (0.2)
Cleaning and upkeep	53.6	41.9	-11.8 (0.4)	4.7	3.5	-1.2 (0.1)
4 Unpaid caregiving	41.1	51.5	10.4 (0.6)	11.8	15.2	3.4 (0.3)
Childcare	39.6	49.5	9.9 (0.6)	10.9	14.0	3.1 (0.2)
Care of dependent adults	0.6	0.8	0.2 (0.0)	0.3	0.3	0.0 (0.0)
5 Volunteer and other unpaid work	2.3	1.4	-0.8 (0.1)	3.2	1.4	-1.8 (0.2)
6 Learning	40.3	40.7	0.4 (0.7)	53.0	47.9	-5.1 (0.9)
7 Socialising and religious practice	99.2	108.4	9.2 (1.0)	105.1	104.2	-1.0 (1.0)
8 Leisure, mass media and sports	133.5	137.4	3.8 (1.1)	135.1	156.7	21.6 (1.0)
Mass media	74.1	76.1	2.1 (0.9)	72.5	86.1	13.6 (0.8)
9 Self-care and maintenance	729.7	710.8	-18.9 (1.2)	742.2	718.4	-23.8 (1.1)
Sleep	550.0	543.6	-6.4 (1.0)	539.1	532.5	-6.6 (0.9)
Eating and drinking	105.4	98.4	-7.0 (0.6)	119.6	110.9	-8.7 (0.6)
Personal hygiene and care	70.9	66.2	-4.7 (0.4)	78.2	71.6	-6.6 (0.4)

Note:
Fetching water and fuel is part of own-use production, following ICATUS 2016. Standard errors clustered by first-stage unit within year.

Table 10: Women: change in minutes per day within usual principal activity status, 2019 to 2024

Usual principal status	Employment (1)	Production work (1+2)	Unpaid work (3+4)
Self-employed	-4.8 (4.9)	-18.9 (3.7)	18.3 (3.3)
Unpaid family helper	49.5 (6.1)	26.7 (5.3)	-8.6 (3.6)
Regular wage/salaried	3.7 (4.0)	1.8 (3.9)	0.1 (3.3)
Casual labour	22.9 (4.5)	15.5 (4.2)	-5.8 (2.8)
Domestic duties	-2.4 (0.5)	-2.8 (1.0)	2.5 (1.6)
Student	-2.9 (0.9)	-4.7 (1.0)	-10.8 (2.1)
Other not working	-5.0 (0.9)	-6.1 (1.3)	13.9 (3.4)

Note:
Women aged 15 and over. Standard errors in parentheses, clustered by first-stage unit within year.